

Session 12: Noah the Righteous Remnant

Key Takeaways

- A key concept for understanding the narrative flow of the whole Bible is that the righteousness of one can count for the many. The story of Noah is first time we see this in the Bible.
- The Bible itself provides the questions to interrogate God's character.

Divine Speech #2: Translation and Literary Design of 7:1-5

¹ And Yahweh said to Noah,

“**Go**, **you** and all your household, into **the ark**
for **you** I have seen as a righteous one before me in this generation.

- a ² You will take for yourself
- b **from every pure animal**,
 - c **seven each**, a man and his wife,
 - b' **and from the animal which is not pure**,
 - b' **two each**, a man and his wife,
 - b'' ³ **also from the birds of the skies**,
 - c'' **seven each**, male and female,

- a **to keep alive** seed on the **face of the land**.
- b ⁴ For in **seven days** more,
 - c **I will send rain** on the land
 - b' **forty days** and forty nights;
 - c' **and I will wipe away** every standing-thing that I have made
 - a' from the **face of the land**.”

⁵ And Noah did
according to all that Yahweh had commanded him.

Genesis 7:1-5. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

Observations on Speech #2

- The opening and closing narrative reports correspond in terms of command and fulfillment.
- The three movements of the speech go from Noah’s character, which warrants the following directives, to God’s command that he rescue the animals and keep them alive.
- This speech seems especially tuned into the garden narrative, where humans are both priests and caretakers of the animals, which explains the purity categories that differentiate the animals. Notice also the vocabulary of “causing rain” (7:4 מַמְטִיר) links back to the beginning of the garden narrative (2:2-5 “before there was yet rain”).

Observations on the Relationships Between the Two Speeches

- Both speeches begin with a report of divine speech and end with statements of Noah’s action according to what was commanded.
- Speech #1 begins by focusing on the corruption of the land that warrants the flood of judgment, while speech #2 begins with Noah’s right standing before God.
- Speech #1 alone has instructions for the making of the ark; speech #2 assumes the existence of an ark to enter into.
- Speech #1 directs Noah to bring his family and the animals into the ark. The animals are described in the language of Genesis 1 (“after their kind” and birds/animals/creepers refer back to Gen. 1:21, 24-25). In speech #2, the animals are described in priestly categories using the language of the garden story (“a man and his wife,” “two” refer to Gen. 2:23-24).

Noah the Righteous Remnant

In Genesis 7:1, God reaffirms Noah’s righteous character, which was first stated by the narrator in 6:8-9. But the repetition is strategic because a key narrative moment takes place between the two statements.

Narrator’s Statement	Noah’s Obedience	God’s Statement	
Genesis 6:8-9 Noah found favor in the eyes of Yahweh. Noah was a righteous man , blameless he was in his generations . Noah walked with God.	Genesis 6:13-14 The end of all flesh has come before me, for the land is filled with violence before them ... Make for yourself an ark ...	Genesis 6:22 And Noah did according to everything that Elohim commanded him, so he did it.	Genesis 7:1 Go, you and all your house into the ark, for I have seen that you are righteous before me in this generation .
<i>Noah’s Righteousness.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).			

Noah’s actions in the intervening narrative connect the narrator’s statement and God’s statement in an action-consequence relationship: Noah was a righteous man already, but God’s command to him was a test to prove his character. Noah passes the test, and God then reaffirms his promise of salvation.

God provides the place of refuge for the righteous remnant.

“[I]t is significant that only immediately before his final entry into the ark did Noah learn of God’s plan to destroy mankind by a flood. Of course, only by this communication could the meaning of the ark and its purpose become clear to him. Therefore, Noah completed the entire structure without knowing God’s intentions; he had only the command which drove him to blind obedience. But that was just Yahweh’s intention—to test Noah. To Noah the command must have seemed strange and incomprehensible. A ship on dry land! That was a test of his obedience and faith. But he passed the test, just as Abraham later followed God’s command implicitly ([Gen. 12:4](#)). ‘By faith Noah being warned by God concerning events as yet unseen, took heed and constructed an ark for the saving of his household.’ ([Heb. 11:7](#)). When one sees that [the narrator] here tells of a test of faith that was passed, then one also understands the judgment which Noah now learns from God’s mouth (i.e., after the command to build and his completion of the building). The [narrator] did not simply assert Noah’s ‘righteousness’ ... but he described it! Unfortunately, we have no satisfactory English word for the theologically significant word *ṣaddīq* (‘righteous’). According to the Old Testament the *ṣaddīq* (‘righteous person’) does justice to a relationship in which he stands. If God abides by his covenant, acts according to the covenant, then he is ‘righteous.’ If a human stands in right relation to God, i.e., believes, trusts God, then he is ‘righteous.’ Righteousness in this sense is not a juridical term of relation, but rather a theological one (see also at Gen. 15:6).”

Von Rad, Gerhard (1973). [Genesis: A Commentary](#). Westminster John Knox Press.

Reflection Question

God rescues Noah’s entire family on account of Noah’s righteous obedience. What does this invite us to consider about God's nature and the way he interacts with people?